

Sanguinaria canadensis

(Papaveraceae)

Bloodroot

Description Perennial plant growing to 6 in (15 cm). Has palm-shaped leaves and solitary flower stems bearing attractive white flowers with 8–12 petals.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to northeastern North America, bloodroot grows in shady woods. It is cultivated as a garden plant. The rhizome is unearthed in summer or autumn.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents Bloodroot contains isoquinoline alkaloids, notably sanguinarine (1%), and many others, including berberine. Sanguinarine is a strongly expectorant substance that also has antiseptic and local anaesthetic properties.

History & Folklore Bloodroot was a traditional remedy of Native Americans, who used it to treat fevers and rheumatism, to induce vomiting, and as an element in divination. The rhizome's bright red juice has been used as a rouge. From 1820 to 1926, bloodroot was listed as an expectorant in the *Pharmacopoeia of the United States*.

Medicinal Actions & Uses

In contemporary herbal medicine, bloodroot is chiefly employed as an expectorant, promoting coughing and the clearing of mucus from the respiratory tract. The plant is prescribed for chronic bronchitis and—as it also has an antispasmodic effect—for asthma and whooping cough. Bloodroot may also be used as a gargle for sore throats, and as a wash or ointment for fungal and viral skin conditions such as athlete's foot and warts.

⚠ **Cautions** Take only under professional supervision and do not exceed the dose. Bloodroot induces vomiting in all but very small doses, and at excessive doses it is toxic. Do not take during pregnancy, while breastfeeding, or if suffering from glaucoma.



Blood root

*Sanguisorba officinalis*syn. *Poterium officinalis* (Rosaceae)

Greater Burnet

Description Perennial herb growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has long-stalked compound leaves with 13 leaflets, and purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, North Africa, and temperate regions of Asia,

greater burnet flourishes in damp pastures, especially in mountainous regions. It is cultivated as a fodder crop and as a salad vegetable, and is gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Greater burnet contains tannins, including sanguisorbic acid, dilactone (a phenolic acid), and gum.

History & Folklore In Europe, greater burnet has long been used as a fodder for animals and as an ingredient in beer-making. As its Latin name implies, it has also been employed as a wound healer: *sanguis* means “blood”; *sorbeo* means “I staunch.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Greater burnet is still used to slow or arrest blood flow. In both the Chinese and European traditions, it is taken internally to treat heavy periods and uterine hemorrhage. Externally, a lotion or ointment may be used for hemorrhoids, burns, wounds, and eczema. Greater burnet is also a valuable astringent and is employed for a variety of gastrointestinal problems, including diarrhea, dysentery, and ulcerative colitis, particularly if accompanied by bleeding.

Research Chinese research indicates that the whole herb heals burns more effectively than the extracted tannins. Patients suffering from eczema showed marked improvement when treated with an ointment made from greater burnet root and petroleum jelly.

Sanicula europaea (Apiaceae)

Sanicle

Description Perennial growing to 16 in (40 cm). Has long-stalked, palm-shaped, shiny leaves, with clusters of pale pink to greenish-white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Found throughout most of Europe and western and central Asia, sanicle is common in woodland areas, particularly in damp shady sites. It is collected in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Sanicle contains up to 13% saponins, allantoin, a volatile oil, tannins, chlorogenic and rosmarinic acid, mucilage, and vitamin C. Allantoin increases the healing rate of damaged tissue. Rosmarinic acid is anti-inflammatory.

History & Folklore Sanicle derives from *sanus*, meaning “whole” or “sound” in Latin. St. Hildegard of Bingen (1098–1179), who wrote the earliest extant description of sanicle's use in healing wounds, states of the herb that it “is hot, and there is much purity in it, and its juice is sweet and healthful, that is wholesome.” During the 15th and 16th centuries sanicle became a popular herbal medicine. The 17th-century English herbalist Nicholas Culpeper praised sanicle's ability “to heal all green wounds

speedily, or any ulcer, imposthumes, or bleedings inwardly,” and compared its benefits to those of comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138) and self-heal (*Prunella vulgaris*, p. 256).

Medicinal Actions & Uses With its longstanding reputation for healing wounds and treating internal bleeding, sanicle is a potentially valuable plant, but it is little used in contemporary herbal medicine. Sanicle may be used to treat bleeding within the stomach or intestines, the coughing up of blood, and nosebleeds. It may also be of use in treating diarrhea and dysentery, bronchial and congestive problems, and sore throats. This herb is traditionally thought to be detoxifying and has also been taken internally for skin problems. Externally, sanicle may be applied in the form of a poultice or ointment for the treatment of wounds, burns, chilblains, hemorrhoids, and inflamed skin.

Santalum album (Santalaceae)

Sandalwood,

Chandan

Description Semiparasitic evergreen tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has lance-shaped leaves, clusters of pale yellow to purple flowers, and small, nearly black fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to eastern India, sandalwood is cultivated in Southeast Asia for its wood and essential oil. The trees are felled throughout the year.

Parts Used Wood, essential oil.

Constituents Sandalwood contains 3–6% volatile oil (which consists predominantly of the sesquiterpenols alpha- and beta-santalol), resin, and tannins.

History & Folklore

Sandalwood's aroma has been highly esteemed in China and India for thousands of years. The wood is often burned as incense and plays a part in Hindu ritual. The heartwood is most often used in perfumery, but it has also been taken as a remedy in China since around 500 CE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sandalwood and its essential oil are used for their antiseptic properties in treating genitourinary conditions such as cystitis and gonorrhea. In Ayurvedic medicine, a paste of the wood is used to soothe rashes and itchy skin. In China, sandalwood is held to be useful for chest and abdominal pain.

Caution Do not take sandalwood essential oil internally.



Sandalwood